

Visitor Studies

ISSN: 1064-5578 (Print) 1934-7715 (Online) Journal homepage: http://www.tandfonline.com/loi/uvst20

Roppola, T. (2012). Designing for the Museum Visitor Experience. New York, NY: Routledge. 322 pages. ISBN: 9780415891844 (hbk), USD $140.00; ISBN 9781138825277 (pbk), USD $54.95.

Maria Xanthoudaki

To cite this article: Maria Xanthoudaki (2015) Roppola, T. (2012). Designing for the Museum Visitor Experience. New York, NY: Routledge. 322 pages. ISBN: 9780415891844 (hbk), USD $140.00; ISBN 9781138825277 (pbk), USD $54.95., Visitor Studies, 18:2, 236-238, DOI: 10.1080/10645578.2015.1079108

To link to this article: http://dx.doi.org/10.1080/10645578.2015.1079108

Published online: 13 Oct 2015.

Submit your article to this journal

Article views: 17

View related articles

View Crossmark data

Full Terms & Conditions of access and use can be found at
http://www.tandfonline.com/action/journalInformation?journalCode=uvst20

Download by: [Maria Xanthoudaki] **Date:** 24 November 2015, At: 04:28

Visitor Studies, 2015, *18*(2), 236–238
Copyright © Visitor Studies Association
ISSN: 1064–5578 print / 1934-7715 online
DOI: 10.1080/10645578.2015.1079108

Book Review

Roppola, T. (2012). *Designing for the Museum Visitor Experience*. New York, NY: Routledge. 322 pages. ISBN: 9780415891844 (hbk), USD $140.00; ISBN 9781138825277 (pbk), USD $54.95.

Reviewed by Maria Xanthoudaki
National Museum of Science and Technology, Milan, Italy

Downloaded by [Maria Xanthoudaki] at 04:28 24 November 2015

This book could have been written by a museum educator, but it is not. This is not a bad thing—on the contrary, it offers a fresh insight on issues up to now usually addressed by museum learning experts or researchers with a learning agenda. Tiina Roppola is an expert in visitor experience having worked for a long time in interpretation and in science communication. Her attempt here is to write from "inside the visitor experience" with the eyes of an exhibition designer. This, in my view, makes the book an important contribution to professional reflection for several reasons.

First of all, attempts to research and write about the visitor experience from the stance of an "exhibition-designer as researcher" are lacking in the field and in the literature. Roppola acknowledges the "limited disciplinary knowledge undergirding exhibition design," arguing that the practice still "finds itself appreciably directed by tacit experience and professional know-how." Her research seems to be an effort to fill this gap and push exhibition designers to become audience advocates by reflecting on visitor experience in relation to design choices.

But it is not just that. Roppola's challenge is to provide a framework in which not only exhibition designers but also interpreters, curators, educators, evaluators, audience advocates, and museum scholars can "*share* and discuss the need to understand the visitor experience in order to design for it effectively" (my emphasis). This is something that rarely happens. In the process of developing exhibitions, exhibition designers, interpreters, curators, educators, evaluators, and audience advocates often build on their own specific bodies of professional knowledge (both practice- and theory-driven) and on their own priorities and repertoires of practice. They advocate what they treasure—what they are there for—but they may not necessarily see such knowledge, priorities, or repertoires in an integrated way. However, sharing an understanding of the visitor experience across museum professionals could make the difference in the quality and impact of our work and, consequently, in the visitor experience itself. It would mean not only grasping the richness and uniqueness of the visitor experience but also building a shared understanding of the difference museums can make in people's lives, as Roppola argues. To do this, according to the author,

we need to build a deeper conceptualization of the visitor experience in relation to exhibition design discourse and see the knowledge developed through visitor studies more directly connected to design choices.

In other words, to do this we need to reflect on the relationship between visitors and exhibitions, "on the inter-relatedness of person and place." Roppola's research goes in this direction. Through the study of about 300 visitors to six institutions of different natures—two museums of natural and cultural history, two science and technology centers, a war museum/memorial, and an immigration-themed museum—she came up with what she calls "four key relational processes": framing, resonating, channeling, and broadening. The book, after an extensive discussion of how experience has been conceptualized in the museum field and the presentation of the research design, is mostly dedicated to the analysis of the four processes.

In brief, *framing* refers to "what makes a museum a museum"; that is, to the conceptualization of the exhibition environment through visitors' expectations and ways of participation. *Frames* are important for visitors' acknowledgement of the museum as a unique communication medium, but at the same time they constitute important elements for institutional change. *Resonating* refers to those body and brain encounters of the constitutive elements of an exhibition that make meaning for each visitor. *Channeling* means the physical, perceptual, and conceptual accompanying of visitors in the vast valley of stimuli of a museum exhibition. It refers to the combination of the "arrangements of stuff" by the museum aimed to help visitors build their experience and their own meaningful narratives. Finally, *broadening* is the context in which visitors make meaning; it encloses those ways through which visitors "find themselves in relationship with the interpretive content of the museum."

In my view, Roppola's work opens up to reflection on facilitation in museums and its potential for influencing the visitor experience. Exhibitions seem to acquire a facilitation role as important and direct as the face-to-face facilitation strongly promoted by museum learning experts. Up to now, facilitation has been one of the priorities of museum learning experts, who have invested in researching and theorizing it, in developing methods and tools for it, and in organizing training in it. Facilitation has been extensively examined in the context of experimental activities, guided tours, gallery floor support, and any other situation involving human interaction.

Recently, formal and informal discussions among museum professionals have led to a widening of what we consider as facilitation, a term which now seems to accommodate many contexts and tools such as exhibitions, interpretive signage, and interactives. Facilitation is considered to be what transforms the institution's collections, content, and expertise into learning experiences that reflect the needs and interests of audiences. The findings of the research as they are presented in the book can be seen in the context of exhibitions—or "mediated environments," according to the author—as facilitation tools.

Roppola's considerations help us realize that not only visitor experience needs to be seen in relation to exhibition design discourse, but that design choices also need to be considered in relation to facilitation as knowledge and practice. Indeed, Roppola argues that "theoretical and empirical museum studies have not reached their potential in impacting exhibition design as these studies have been working within 'underdeveloped' or under-articulated conceptualizations of [the] visitor experience."

Downloaded by [Maria Xanthoudaki] at 04:28 24 November 2015

However, I would argue the opposite as well. Visitor studies have not been used enough in design choices probably because they are often considered only connected to, or relevant for, learning in museums.

In my view, Roppola's call for a framework encouraging a shared understanding across museum professionals is even more important today. We need to go beyond the ranking of responsibilities or the defense of specific interests in museum practice. If we believe that we share the mission of wanting to make a difference in people's lives we need to work in a more integrated way.

ABOUT THE REVIEWER

Maria Xanthoudaki is Director of Education, National Museum of Science and Technology, Milan, Italy. E-mail: xanthoudaki@museoscienza.it

Downloaded by [Maria Xanthoudaki] at 04:28 24 November 2015